

The Hollow Crown of Vehl

a series in ten books

BOOK I

The Eighth Ash

— Chapter Four —

CHAPTER IV

A Body That Could Almost Walk Up Stairs

The other six niches were not in the lower passage.

Kael learned this in the first sixty seconds of walking back the way they had come, when the Ledger — which had remained quiet on the question of where to find the other anchors of the saint of the Glass Choir while he was standing in the reliquary, the way the Ledger remained quiet on most questions in the rooms where the answers lived — began, in the corridor, to talk.

Updated map.

Six niches of equivalent provenance, in this complex:

- Reliquary 1 (this floor, east, accessible)
- Reliquary 2 (this floor, north, behind iron door, sealed)
- Reliquary 3 (one level up, in the chamber you woke in, behind the altar slab – disturbed)
- Reliquary 4 (one level up, west wing, occupied)
- Reliquary 5 (two levels up, in the chapel proper, public)
- Reliquary 6 (location unknown to me – masked)

Kael read the line and stopped walking.

He stood in the lower passage with the bone in his clawed left hand and the note against his collarbone and read the line a second time, and the part of it that he could not stop returning to was the smallest word, in the very last entry, and that word was *me*.

The Ledger had said *me*.

For an hour now the Ledger had spoken in clean impersonal accounting terms — Recommended. Estimated. Identified. — and Kael had read it the way he had read his old insurance contracts, with the

inattention paid to a voice that had no voice. He had thought, in passing, of the Ledger as an interface. He had been wrong. The Ledger had been writing as an interface because that was the format that suited it; the Ledger could, when it pleased, write as a person.

The Ledger had just used a first-person pronoun about a piece of its own ignorance.

Location unknown to me. Masked.

He felt — and he attended to the feeling, because attending was free and the price of not attending was usually steep — a small cold pleasure run up the inside of his small new chest. He had been promoted. He had not had to ask. The Ledger, somewhere between the chamber above and the reliquary behind him, had decided that he was worth speaking to as a person.

He filed the promotion and made himself think nothing about it that the Ledger might misinterpret as gratitude. Gratitude could, he had recently learned, cost him a stage.

"Aren Mosk."

The cultist stopped two paces behind him. "Yes."

"The reliquary in the west wing of this level. Reliquary four. You said this complex has a House of Seven Rooms. Is one of them the west wing reliquary."

A long pause. Aren Mosk had not been thinking of the complex in this geometry. He had been thinking of it as the chamber, the lower passage, and the way out. He worked through it now, slowly, with his grey eyes looking at the middle distance the way a man looks at a thing he is trying to remember the shape of.

"Yes," he said at last. "The west wing reliquary is — it's where the Brother kept the older relics. The ones we weren't allowed to touch. The door is iron, and it's locked from inside the chapel, not from out here. I have never been inside it."

"Who has."

"Only the Brother. And — and one other. The woman who used to read the manuscripts. The Brother's scribe. She was here for the first year, and then she stopped coming."

"Her name."

A small surprised pause. He had clearly not, in three weeks of preparing for the ritual, expected to be asked her name. He worked his mouth open. "Sera. I think. Sera Ilyne. Vasquaire."

Kael did not move.

He did not move because the small clean cold feeling in his chest had become, on hearing the name, a very precise click — the click of two halves of a thing fitting together. S., the letter had been signed. He had wondered, half-attentively, what the S. stood for. He had not, in the back of his small head, considered Sera; he had considered, in the order his calculations preferred, Selene, Saskia, Solveig, Saara, the names that had felt available in his old life's vocabulary of

women he had not known. He had not considered Sera. He had not yet known, until this moment, that this world had Seras in it.

The Ledger, behind his eye, did not say anything.

The Ledger, Kael noted, *very specifically* did not say anything.

He considered the silence the way he considered the other silences he had collected today, and he set it down beside them. The Ledger had been told, by the structure of the situation, what Aren Mosk had just told Kael. The Ledger could see Aren Mosk's mouth move. The Ledger had not chosen to identify Sera Ilyne Vasquaire as the writer of the note. The Ledger was, instead, leaving Kael to make the connection himself.

The Ledger was, he thought, very deliberately, *teaching* him.

He let his small shoulders settle a fraction.

"How long has she not been here," he said.

"Two years. A little more."

"How much do you trust your memory of the date she left."

"Not well. The Brother — the Brother handles dates."

"How well do you trust your memory of *her*."

Aren Mosk thought about this for several seconds.

"Better. She used to bring biscuits. She did not believe what we believed. She was — she was, I think, only here because the Brother had asked her, and because she wanted to read the manuscripts. She was very tall. She had eyes like cold water."

"Was she silver-haired."

"Yes."

Kael made a small unobtrusive note inside himself. The Ledger, behind his eye, finally said something — a single small line, very quiet.

You may proceed to your inferences. They will be correct.

Kael let the smallest fraction of his small wrong mouth turn upward.

"All right," he said aloud, to himself, to the Ledger, to Aren Mosk and the corridor and the soft cold air and the night-by-now of a Tuesday in a world he had not yet seen the sky of. "All right. Reliquary two is sealed. Reliquary three is in the chamber where we will be ambushed within the hour. Reliquary four is behind an iron door we cannot open. Reliquary five is in a public chapel. Reliquary six is masked." He paused. "Which means."

He looked at Aren Mosk.

"Which means," Aren Mosk said carefully, "the route is — five. The chapel. Up two levels."

"And up two levels we will encounter."

"The chapel attendants. The brothers of the second circle. The. The novice dormitory if we pass through the wrong door."

"How many men."

A swallow. "At this hour. Five, maybe six. Awake. Perhaps a dozen more asleep within shouting distance."

"How long until shouting distance becomes armed distance."

"If they shout, two minutes. The watch keeps a barracks in the side chapel."

Kael read the air for several seconds and rebuilt his outside window. They were now twenty-eight minutes from the chamber's grating being audible to armed men. The chapel above was occupied and would not stay quiet. The reliquary in the chamber above was disturbed, which meant the surviving cultists had likely already passed through or were heading back to it.

There was no clean route up. There was, at most, a route up that he could survive long enough to learn whether the bone in his hand and the failing coat on it would do what S. had implied it could do.

He looked at the bone.

He looked at the Ledger.

Recommended next move:

Do not attempt the chapel.
Use the bone here, below.

A summoning conducted in the lower passage will not be felt by the chapel attendants and will not register against the Brother's wards.

Cost: 4 Hunger.

Result: ambiguous. the bone is keyed to "a substitute";
the substitute is keyed to "what is needful."
the Ledger advises you to ask before you pay.

What is needful, Kael thought.

He read the line twice. He held the bone up to his small face and looked at the failing coat of debt on it with the new sight, and he thought, with the cold clarity of a man

who had run actuarial models on insurance fraud for nine years, that "needful" was a polite word that did a great deal of work it was not advertising.

Need is, he thought, the most expensive word in any language.

He thought about S. He thought about a woman with silver hair and cold-water eyes who had two years ago stopped coming to a cult complex below the city of Tannev, and who had — at some point — come back, alone, knowing what the Brother was preparing for, and had taken a real fragment of a saint's body from one of the niches and replaced it with a forgery she had built with her own hands, and had left a note on the cushion, and had taken the genuine relic away. He thought about what she might have done with the genuine relic. He thought about what *needful* meant in a sentence written by someone who had had, two years ago, the foresight to plan for this evening.

He thought: she has set me a key.

She has set a key. The bone is the key. The lock is whatever the bone summons, in the place where it is summoned. She knew I would arrive in this complex; she did not know what stage I would be at; she did not know how badly I would be hurt; she did not know what I would need. So she set a key that would summon, on use, what I needed.

A general-purpose summon. A key that opens whatever door is in front of you.

He thought: this is very clever. It is also very expensive.

She had paid the cost of the forgery herself. She had paid the cost of returning to the complex herself. She had paid the cost of trusting that the eighth Candidate would be a person worth arming. She had taken three large bets in a row, with her own life on the table, on a person she had not met, and had folded into the note an apology and a hope and the word *sorry*.

He looked at the Hunger line on the Ledger. He had five points of Hunger and the summoning cost four.

He thought: this leaves me one Hunger point until I rest.

He thought: she would have known what an Imp's Hunger budget looks like, because she has read about Imps. She is offering me the most expensive cheap thing she could afford to offer me. The cost is calibrated to be just barely affordable.

He thought: I should take it.

He thought, with mild and not unpleasant surprise: I want to take it.

He stood for a moment in the cold corridor with the bone in his hand and let himself, briefly, want a thing. He had not, in many years of his old life, wanted very much. He had liked his work. He had liked, in a quiet way, certain foods. He had liked, very privately, certain pieces of music. He had not *wanted* in the way a man wants to win at a game whose pieces he has only just been given. He let himself, for the length of one small breath, attend to the wanting.

Then he set it down beside the other things, and he picked up the bone, and he said, "Aren Mosk. Step back two paces. Press your back to the wall. Cover your eyes. If something appears in this corridor that is not me, do not interfere with it. Do not greet it. Do not speak to it. Do not, under any circumstances, attempt to bind it."

"Yes."

Aren Mosk stepped back. He pressed his back to the wall. He covered his eyes.

Kael held the bone in his small purple hand and he closed his small wrong eyes and he thought, with the part of himself that the Ledger could hear: I will pay four Hunger. Summon what is needful.

He thought it.

He did not say it.

The Ledger, behind his eye, ticked. It went down to one.

The bone in his hand went out.

The coat of debt that S. had layered onto the surface of the bone — the thing that had let it read as a relic of Saint Aelirhen of Six Tongues, the thing that had given the cult their seventh anchor — sloughed off the bone in a slow wave of cold blue light and was, in the air of the lower passage, *spent*. The bone in his hand became a small worn thing the color of weak tea, ordinary, used, no longer holding anything. He felt it go cool in his palm. He felt the air in the corridor shift, very slightly, the way air shifts in a room where a window has just been opened to a room that is not, technically, a room.

Then he heard, very softly, behind him, the sound of fabric.

Not boots. Not breath. Fabric. The slow soft slither of cloth touching cloth, the way a long robe makes its own small song as the wearer turns.

Kael opened his eyes and did not, immediately, turn his head.

He could feel, with the new sight, that something had appeared in the corridor approximately seven paces behind him, in the empty stretch of dressed stone between his position and the hatch. He could feel it because it was glowing. It was not glowing the way the bone had glowed; it was glowing the way the *blood* had glowed on Aren Mosk's hands — warm, alive, the deep amber of a held debt that had a body around it.

It was, in other words, a person.

He had summoned a person.

He turned, slowly.

She was perhaps five feet from him, just past the place where the lower passage widened a fraction toward the reliquary arch. She was very tall — even by adult human standards she was tall, and to Kael's eighteen inches she was a column. She was wearing a long dark

traveling cloak, soaked in places at the hem with the wet of stone she had walked through, and her hands, which were the only part of her below the cloak's neckline that he could see, were ungloved and very pale. Her hood was up.

She was standing perfectly still. She had appeared standing. She had not stumbled. She had not, in the moment of her arrival, made the small confused sound of a person who has been moved against their will from one place to another. She had appeared the way an actor appears on a stage when the lights come up.

She was, Kael understood with a small cold delight, *expecting* this.

Slowly, she pushed the hood back.

The face inside the hood was the face of a woman of perhaps twenty-eight, with skin so pale it seemed almost to hold its own faint light, and hair the color of cold silver braided in a thick rope down her left shoulder, and eyes — Aren Mosk had been correct —

like cold water. The eyes were not unkind. They were not warm either. They were the eyes of a woman who had been reading too much, for too long, in too cold a room.

She looked at Kael.

She looked at him properly. Not at his strangeness. Not at his small wrong purpleness. At his face. She held his eye, and her mouth — pale, full, very slightly chapped — turned at the corners in a small wry shape that was not a smile but was, perhaps, the long-overdue cousin of one.

"Eighth," she said.

Her voice was lower than he had expected. It was a reading voice. A library voice. A voice that had spent more time on vellum than on people.

"S.," Kael said. The small chittering wrong voice was very nearly steady this time. He was, he registered with a moment of mild surprise, holding it steady on

purpose.

"Sera." She made a small careful motion with her left hand, palm down, like a person calming an animal. "If you will. My given name is Sera. I am sorry that I did not address you by yours in the letter. I did not know it."

"You know it now."

"Yes." She paused. "Kael, the Ledger says."

Kael did not, immediately, answer. He let himself, for the length of one slow breath, look at her — the way she stood, the way the cloak fell, the way her left hand held a small bag of something at her hip and her right hand hung empty and ready, the way her right hip carried — he saw it now, looking properly, the small subtle bulk of it under the cloak — a sheathed something at the belt, not a sword, something smaller, a knife or a wand or a tally-rod, he did not yet know.

He let the looking inform him. He did not — he was sure of this — let his face show that the looking was

happening.

She let him look. She did not move.

This was, he understood, a courtesy. She had agreed, somewhere in the half-second between her arrival and her speaking, that he was a person who needed to look at her before they could begin, and she had stood still for him. He had not been, in his old life, in the room with very many people who would do that.

"Sera Ilyne Vasquaire," he said, when he had finished looking, "I am Kael Veyne. I read your letter. I have used your bone."

She nodded, once. "Then we should begin."

"You expected to be summoned."

"I built the substitute keyed to need. I am, at the moment in this room when the Eighth Ash will summon what is needful, the most useful person who could be retrieved by name and brought through the Ash to here. Yes. I expected this."

"You arranged for yourself to be the summon."

"Yes."

"It cost you something."

She tilted her head fractionally. "Some. Less than you would think. I was, when the summoning fired, four hundred paces from here in a cellar I keep for this kind of work. The cost was the cost of crossing four hundred paces of the lower Ash. Roughly one bad night and one nosebleed." Her mouth twitched. "I have had, in the last two years, worse."

"You have been waiting for this evening for two years."

"Nineteen months. I learned of the rite eighteen months ago. I have been preparing it for seventeen."

"You did not warn the cult."

"No."

"Why."

She did not, immediately, answer.

She looked at Aren Mosk — who had, at some point in the last sixty seconds, taken his hands away from his eyes and was watching her with the bloodless, flat-mouthed attention of a man recognizing, very slowly, a person he had known. She held his look. He did not, Kael saw, look away. He held her eyes the way he had held Kael's: with the awful tired courage of a man who had spent the last hour finding out, in real time, what he was made of.

"Aren," she said.

He blinked. He said, in a voice that was almost his own and not quite, "Sera."

"You held a door for me," she said, "in this complex, twenty-eight months ago, when I brought down a load of books I had been told to deliver. You did not have to. You did it because I had my hands full. I remember that, Aren Mosk. I am sorry I am only able to come back for one of you."

He looked at her for a long moment.

Then he said, very softly: "I am not the one you came back for."

"I know."

He nodded, once.

He sat, slowly, on the floor of the lower passage with his back to the wall, and he put his head down between his knees, and he began — for the second time in two hours — to weep. He did not, this time, weep loudly. He wept the way a man weeps when something has been carried for a very long time and has, in the last five minutes, been very carefully set down by someone else.

Kael did not turn around.

Sera did not turn either. She looked, instead, at Kael, and her cold-water eyes held a small wet pity in them that was — Kael saw clearly — not for him.

"To your question," she said. "Why I did not warn the cult. The short answer is that the cult could not have been warned. The Brother runs the cult, and the Brother is not what the cult thinks. The Brother is older than the cult and he is using the cult, and the cult — Aren and the seven who ran tonight and the four dozen others in the upper levels — would have died if I had warned them, because the Brother would have noticed the warning and have killed them all and replaced them with new ones. The slow death of this cult, over the year I have been carving the substitute, was the price I paid for not killing all of them in a week. I knew Aren would survive tonight only because of one thing. I knew the rite would summon an Imp. I knew the Imp would be of a particular shape. I knew, when I left the substitute and the letter, that there was a one-in-three chance that the Imp would kill all of them in the first thirty seconds, and a two-in-three chance that the Imp would, instead, perform the Reroute and kill only the binder and spare one of the others, and that that other would be Aren, because Aren was the only one of the

eight who had ever done a small unprompted kindness in this complex, and the Ledger — even on the day a Demon Lord dies — prefers to round in favor of debt held by a soul that has been kind."

Kael held this in his small chest for a long moment.

He thought: the Ledger has opinions. Yes. I had wondered.

"You are saying," he said, "that I spared Aren Mosk because the Ledger preferred it."

"No." She shook her head, just once. The braid did not move. "I am saying that the Ledger preferred it, and that you, on instinct, did the thing the Ledger preferred. The Ledger is not in your head, Kael. The Ledger is in the world. It is also in you. You did the thing because you are now, in some small way, a creature of it. You will, over time, be a larger one." She paused. "I do not, in case you wish to know, find this development frightening."

"You will, in time."

"Possibly. Not tonight."

Kael looked at her for what was, he calculated, almost six full seconds. He could not, in his old life, recall having spent six seconds in silent looking at another adult of his own species, and the look had felt long and indulgent and inappropriate the few times he had attempted it. The Imp's body, he was learning, did not feel six seconds as long. The Imp's body felt six seconds as a measurement.

He measured.

He decided.

"Sera Ilyne Vasquaire," he said, "I am at one Hunger. I am at Stage One. I have a cultist with a wounded knee, a book of forgeries, a water-skin, and approximately twenty-five minutes before armed men descend on this complex. I would like, if you are willing, to leave with you. I would also like, if you are willing, to discuss the

terms under which I would like to leave with you. I have a strong intuition that the discussion is, itself, the first interview I am being given for the position. I would like to do it well."

She did, for the first time, fully smile.

It was a small thing — a fractional softening of the cold-water eyes, a deepening of the small wry shape at the corners of the mouth — but it was a smile, and it was, when it arrived, very nearly warm.

"Eighth," she said, "you are doing it well already."

"Then."

"Then yes. We can talk on the way." She turned her head a fraction toward Aren Mosk, who had stopped weeping and was wiping his nose, with quiet dignity, against the sleeve of his bloodied robe. "All three of us. I have a route. It is not the chapel. It is, I am sorry to say, the lower Ash, which neither of you will find pleasant. The advantage is that the Brother does not

watch it. The disadvantage is that it is the Ash."

"How long."

"Two hours, perhaps three. We surface in the cellar of a friend, near the western gate of Tannev."

"In daylight."

"In daylight."

Kael, who had not yet, in this life, seen the sky of this world, registered the daylight the way he registered most things: as a variable he had not yet had time to weigh. He set it down beside the rest. He would weigh it when he saw it.

"All right," he said. He looked down at the bone in his small purple hand. He looked at it for a long moment, and then he set it carefully, with the formal small precision of a man setting down a borrowed thing, on the cold stone of the lower passage. "I will not need this."

She looked at the bone where he had set it down. She looked up at him. "No," she said. "You will not."

He turned to Aren Mosk.

"Up," he said. The chitter had, he registered with a small private pleasure, almost no chitter left in it. He was learning, with this small new mouth, to make sounds that were nearly the sounds of his old voice.

Aren Mosk stood up.

He stood, this time, without help. He brushed the wet from his cheeks with the back of his wrist. He set the book against his chest. He shouldered the water-skin. He looked at Sera. He looked at Kael. He said, in a voice that was hoarse but no longer cracked: "Where do we go."

Sera made the small calming motion with her left hand again, and this time it was, very clearly, a please-follow.

She turned and walked, with the long even stride of a person who had walked this corridor before, back along

the lower passage past the open arch of the reliquary, past the place under the hatch where Aren Mosk had landed badly, and to a section of wall about six paces further on, which was — Kael saw, with the new sight — not a wall. It was a faintly glowing thing wearing the *picture* of a wall. The mortar of it was warm in a way that the mortar of the rest of the corridor was not. The Debt-Sight, at her approach, gave him for the first time the precise shape of the thing she had come here to reveal to him.

It was a door.

A door in the wall of a corridor, leading downward, into a cold deeper place that he had, until this moment, not known was below them.

Sera laid her ungloved right hand flat against the warm mortar, and she said, very softly, a word that was not in any of Kael's languages but that he understood anyway, because the Ledger leaned into the meaning and offered him the translation a half-beat behind her

tongue, the way a good interpreter does: *open*.

The wall opened.

It opened the way water opened, not the way stone opened — the mortar simply *moved*, slowly, with a small unhurried tide, and the stone behind it became, in a long careful breath, a stair descending into a cold black place that smelled, faintly, of nothing.

Sera stepped through.

Aren Mosk followed.

Kael, standing at the lip of the stair on the small thin legs of his small thin body, looked once back down the lower passage — at the open arch of the empty reliquary, at the closed mouth of the hatch above, at the place in the corridor where his bone had been set down and would, by daylight, be picked up by a man who did not know what to make of it — and he understood, in the small private way he had been understanding things all night, that he was, for the first

time in his second life, walking somewhere on purpose.

The Ledger ticked, very quietly, in his small purple chest.

Conditions for advancement to Stage 2 (Cinder-Imp):

2 of 5 met.

- Killed (1)
- Held a debt to one named soul (S. — settled in part)
- Read your Ledger in full (pending)
- Accepted aid from one mortal (pending)
- Walked the lower Ash (pending)

The third condition is upcoming.

Kael read the line. He read it twice. He understood, with the small precise satisfaction of a man watching a proof unfold on a chalkboard, that "accepted aid from one mortal" was not — as he had thought — the same as the condition he had met in the reliquary. That had been *held a debt to one named soul*, and the Ledger had now, with the precision of a clerk, separated them. The next condition was something else. The next condition was an aid he had not yet accepted.

He looked down the stair after Sera.

She was — three steps below him already, the cloak rippling at her shoulders — pausing on the fourth step to look back over her shoulder. The cold-water eyes were not impatient. They were waiting.

He understood.

He walked down to the third step. He stopped. He held out — with a small careful precision he had not, until this evening, owned — his small clawed left hand toward her.

"I cannot," he said, "manage the stairs at this scale."

She looked at the small hand. She looked at his small face. She did not laugh. She did not smile. She bent down, on the fourth step, and she held out, with the same precise careful steadiness, her own ungloved right hand, palm up, fingers slightly cupped — exactly the size of the cup a tall woman makes when she is offering, with formal courtesy, to lift a small thing of considerable consequence.

Kael stepped into her palm.

It was the third deliberate act of his second life.

Conditions for advancement to Stage 2 (Cinder-Imp):
3 of 5 met.

Sera Ilyne Vasquaire lifted Kael Veyne, eighth Candidate for the Hollow Crown, off the stairs and against her shoulder, where he settled, with the surprising obedient grace of his small new tail, against the soft heavy weave of her dark traveling cloak. He fit there. Her hand was warm.

Below him, the small humming returned at the base of his skull — the second tuning fork, the Cognitive Strain, the price the Ledger had warned him about — and then receded, as it had before, with the patience of a thing that had been promised it would come due later.

Sera turned. She walked down the stairs.

Aren Mosk followed.

Behind them, the door in the wall closed, very softly, the mortar coming back up like a tide turning over a beach, and the lower passage of the House of Seven Rooms went, again, dark.

In the corridor it left behind, on the cold dressed stone where Kael Veyne had set down his bone, the small worn finger-bone of a saint of the Glass Choir lay quietly, used up, no longer holding any debt at all. It was, by morning, the only thing in the complex that no longer mattered.

By morning, also, the rest of the complex would no longer matter.

But Kael did not know that yet.

He was, at that moment, very busy.

He was, at that moment, riding on the warm shoulder of a tall woman with silver hair into the underside of a world he had not yet seen, with the second pressure rising at the back of his skull and the Ledger ticking

quietly in his small chest and the cool weight of S.'s note still tucked, very carefully, in the only pouch his body had.

He had, at that moment, three of five conditions met for his second stage.

He had, at that moment, a plan.

He had, at that moment, an ally.

And the Ledger — quiet, attentive, almost gentle — said, behind his right eye, in a small voice that was very nearly his own and not quite:

Walk well, Eighth. The next two conditions are the difficult ones.

— end of Chapter Four —